
Always obvious, the Trump-Nixon parallels are now downright uncanny

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Heather Digby Parton

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Always obvious, the Trump-Nixon parallels are now downright uncanny

Until very recently, the consensus among historians and political observers was that Richard Nixon was the most corrupt president in American history. There had been other scandals, of course, but none of them featured the same crude, gangster quality of Watergate, the details of which shocked and appalled the American people as they were slowly uncovered between 1972 and 1974. We learned that the president of the United States acted like a common thug in private, issuing orders to his enforcers in language closer to that used by the mobsters featured in the recent hit movie “The Godfather” than the dignified leader of the free world.

He was an amateur compared to [Donald Trump](#).

Even after Nixon won reelection in 1972 in what remains one of the [biggest landslide victories](#) in American politics, he was consumed with resentment. Always a sour type who liked to whine that he had always been treated unfairly, he nurtured a long list of grievances against a long list of perceived enemies. The presidency became his vehicle for punishing them. The administration maintained an [enemies list](#), which included reporters, actors, singers, business leaders, political rivals, Democratic donors and others — all for the express purpose of “[using] the available federal machinery to screw our political enemies.”

Much as Trump was stopped by the proverbial “guardrails” during his first term, Nixon was [thwarted](#) in [some of his most nefarious plans](#) by career bureaucrats and members of his administration who refused to follow through on his orders. But it wasn’t just the president who was engaging in shenanigans. His first vice president, Spiro Agnew, was found to have been taking cash bribes for government contracts and was forced to resign from office. He pleaded guilty to one felony count of tax evasion and paid a \$10,000 fine.

The Nixon administration’s corruption and abuse of power was overwhelming. Nixon began his second term in 1973 with an impressive electoral mandate and a 68% approval rating. But as the full picture of Watergate unfolded, his poll numbers [sank dramatically](#), dropping all the way to 24% on the day he left office.

Nixon’s is a familiar story, but it’s worth reexamining in light of events that unfolded over the weekend. On Saturday, Trump [published a very odd post](#) on Truth Social. Addressed specifically to “Pam” — as if it were meant to be a text or a direct message to Attorney General Pam Bondi — it ordered her to take immediate action on prosecuting the enemies on *his* list. The president specifically named Democratic California Sen. Adam Schiff, former FBI Director James Comey and New York Attorney General Letitia James.

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“We can’t delay any longer,” he wrote, “ it’s killing our reputation and credibility, they impeached me twice, and indicted me (5 times!), OVER NOTHING. JUSTICE MUST BE SERVED, NOW!!! President DJT.”

Nixon may have been paranoid but at least he didn’t sound like a petulant teenager.

The post was quickly deleted, and apparently his own staff [wasn't sure](#) if he had meant it to be published. It was promptly reposted, likely because they realized it had already been distributed all over the internet.

It was also reported on Saturday that White House border czar Tom Homan apparently [accepted a \\$50,000 cash bribe](#) in 2024 from undercover FBI agents in exchange for contracts — exactly the same act that sent Agnew packing — and they even have it on tape. But instead of prosecuting Homan or forcing him to resign, he is still employed by the administration. What's more, Trump's Justice Department has [closed an investigation](#) into his activities.

When the evidence in Watergate became undeniable, Republicans in Congress abandoned Nixon. (Arizona Sen. Barry Goldwater famously led a delegation of congressional Republicans to the White House and told the president he would be impeached and removed from office.) Nixon was forced to resign.

But Trump has gone farther than Nixon ever contemplated. After his efforts to overturn the 2020 election, along with the infamous events of Jan. 6, Trump was rewarded with a triumphant return to the White House four years later. Now, as his corruption and retribution have gone into overdrive, he maintains the full and enthusiastic support of his party.

One of the big questions about Watergate has always been whether President Gerald Ford's pardon of Nixon, offered in the spirit of national healing, did more harm than good. It seems clear today that it did. The pardon opened the door to what was possible if only you could maintain partisan political support in Congress, along with a compliant media.

Today, despite the efforts of Congress after Watergate to rein in future presidents, their good faith reliance on norms and rules was clearly not enough. The open door was just waiting for someone like Donald Trump to walk through it. This time, it's just business as usual.

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